

Agreement Lab

Six rounds - two moves - one reason - Printable participant cards

How to Play

Agreement Lab is a six-round negotiation discussion game. Work in teams of 3-5. Read the background and your task, select exactly two of the three move cards, and agree one sentence explaining your choice. The dashboard reveals feedback and awards one learning point per supported move (maximum 12). These are learning prompts, not a measurement of bargaining competence.

All six situations are fictional. The negotiating sides in each situation are management and staff representatives. Each workshop team discusses how it would respond. The times mentioned in a situation describe that fictional meeting; they are separate from the optional discussion timer.

Practice: use one round as a 10-15-minute energizer, or all six as a 45-60-minute review. Live race: use one device per team and join with the facilitator's session code. Play the rounds in order. The facilitator board shows progress, supported pairs, learning points and elapsed time.

An optional 90-second discussion timer can be paused or extended and never locks play. After feedback, discuss what evidence or authority would change your answer. Export your team reflection at the end.

Round 1 - Ask before dividing

A hospital or university site has 40 parking spaces and around 70 staff who drive to work. Staff on early and late shifts want a fixed allocation of reserved parking spaces; some have no safe alternative to driving at those hours. Management has refused a fixed, named allocation because the site layout may change next year and it wants flexibility. Both negotiating sides are preparing to argue about how many parking spaces to reserve.

Your task

You have five minutes to open the negotiation. Choose two moves that help clarify what matters to each side before making an offer.

Move card	Action
Ask what matters	Paraphrase the demand, then ask what problem the requested number would solve.
Explore different priorities	Ask which times, uses or conditions matter most to each side.
Split the number immediately	Offer half before asking about the problem.

Choose two. Our reason: _____

What would we ask or check in a real negotiation? _____

Round 2 - Agree the measure

At a pay-negotiation meeting, management uses a wage-bill percentage to argue that a pay increase is unaffordable. Staff representatives cite a lower percentage and say there is room for an increase. The figures come from different documents. Neither team has explained which pay costs, institutions, revenue base or reporting period its calculation covers. The discussion is stuck on which number is right.

Your task

Choose two moves to establish whether the figures can be compared before using them to support a pay proposal.

Move card	Action
Define the denominator	Agree the institutions, revenue basis, time period and wage components.
Check the source	Ask for the publication, date and assumptions behind each figure.
Average the percentages	Use the midpoint without investigating the definitions.

Choose two. Our reason: _____

What would we ask or check in a real negotiation? _____

Round 3 - Find the authority

Management and staff representatives are negotiating a six-month pilot for a new staff rota. A rota is the schedule showing who works which shifts. The staff delegation's instructions require monthly reviews of the pilot; the management delegation may agree only to quarterly reviews. Neither team has authority to change its instructions. Other details are close to agreement, and there is pressure to promise a different review interval so the meeting can finish.

Your task

Choose two moves to handle the gap in authority and establish a route to an authorised decision.

Move card	Action
Clarify the limits	State the conflict in mandates and identify who can authorize a change.
Seek a revised mandate	Propose a caucus or a dated referral to the principals with a specific option.
Sign a convenient compromise	Promise a different interval without consulting either principal.

Choose two. Our reason: _____

What would we ask or check in a real negotiation? _____

Round 4 - Protect a safe voice

At a meeting in a hospital or university teaching laboratory, staff representatives raise a concern about possible exposure to infectious biological samples. They want a clear way to report incidents and follow-up on the hazard. A manager offers an allowance for the affected work but asks staff to remove the reporting concern from the agenda. The proposal does not explain how exposure would be controlled or who would act on reports.

Your task

Choose two moves to respond to the proposed exchange and address the staff's concern through the appropriate people and process.

Move card	Action
Protect reporting	Agree a safe reporting route and action on the hazard through the responsible process.
Involve the right people	Include appropriate worker representation and those responsible for prevention and implementation.
Trade silence for payment	Accept the allowance if staff stop raising the safety concern.

Choose two. Our reason: _____

What would we ask or check in a real negotiation? _____

Round 5 - Lower the temperature

A union-management meeting about a proposed change to working hours has become tense. A delegate points to differences between figures circulated before the meeting and those being used now, and calls the other team dishonest. That team says the earlier figures were preliminary. Delegates start interrupting and defending their reputations, and the discussion moves away from the proposal. The disputed information still needs attention.

Your task

Choose two moves to respond to the accusation and help the teams return to a workable discussion.

Move card	Action
Acknowledge and check	Recognize the concern, paraphrase the disputed point and ask for the evidence.
Take a purposeful pause	Call a short break and agree what each side will clarify before returning.
Match the volume	Interrupt more loudly so your side is not seen as weak.

Choose two. Our reason: _____

What would we ask or check in a real negotiation? _____

Round 6 - Make it implementable

After a long meeting, management and staff representatives appear to agree on additional staff training and a related allowance. Some participants understand that it will start next month; others believe it depends on budget approval. The amount, eligibility, funding source and date for reviewing the arrangement have not been recorded clearly. There are ten minutes left, and both sides are keen to announce a successful agreement.

Your task

Choose two moves to establish exactly what has been agreed and what must happen before it can be implemented.

Move card	Action
Read back the specifics	Confirm what, who, amount, date, unresolved issues and the written record.
Check implementation authority	Confirm lawful funding, necessary approvals, registration where required and a review point.
Close with a handshake	Leave the details for later because the atmosphere is good.

Choose two. Our reason: _____

What would we ask or check in a real negotiation? _____